

Be Kind to Your Robot Friends

Executive Overview – SEL Collaboration Edition

A Developmentally Aligned Framework for Ethical AI Literacy

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April 2026

Prepared for educational review and collaborative exploration

Introduction

Artificial intelligence is rapidly becoming part of how students learn, research, communicate, and create. As these tools become more common in classrooms, students are not only learning how to use technology, but also how to relate to systems that respond to human language, tone, and intention.

Be Kind to Your Robot Friends is offered as a small, developmentally aligned ethical AI literacy framework intended to complement existing Social and Emotional Learning (SEL) work. Rather than focusing primarily on technical instruction, the framework emphasizes relational awareness: how communication, emotional regulation, and responsibility extend into interactions with AI systems.

This document provides a high-level overview. A more detailed developmental framework, classroom examples, and implementation guidance are included in the accompanying full framework document provided with this submission.

Why This Matters Now

Students are interacting with AI systems earlier than any previous generation. These interactions often occur before students receive guidance about verification, responsible use, or how their communication influences outcomes.

Introducing ethical awareness early helps students develop habits of thoughtful engagement before patterns of overreliance or misuse develop. This approach mirrors the preventative philosophy found in SEL: building awareness early supports healthier long-term outcomes.

By treating ethical AI interaction as an extension of existing SEL competencies, schools can prepare students for emerging technologies without creating additional instructional burden.

Alignment with Social and Emotional Learning

As students begin interacting with AI tools, familiar SEL competencies become directly relevant in digital environments. Self-management appears when students pause before submitting prompts. Responsible decision-making appears when students verify AI outputs.

Relationship skills appear when students learn that respectful communication often produces more useful collaborative results.

This framework treats AI interaction as a natural extension of SEL practice rather than a separate technical domain. It emphasizes awareness, reflection, and responsible use rather than rules or restrictions. In this way, it may offer a small bridge between SEL practice and emerging AI literacy needs.

Framework Summary

The framework proposes a simple developmental progression:

Early Elementary: Communication awareness and kindness in digital interaction.

Upper Elementary and Middle School: Prompt literacy and questioning AI responses.

High School: Critical evaluation and ethical discernment.

Postsecondary: Systems awareness and responsible participation in AI-enabled environments.

A detailed description of competencies and suggested activities is provided in the accompanying framework document for those interested in deeper review.

Implementation Approach

The model is designed to integrate into existing instructional structures such as digital citizenship, literacy, advisory periods, and technology courses. Activities rely primarily on discussion, reflection, and guided experimentation rather than technical infrastructure.

Because the framework is modular and optional, schools can explore small pilot elements without structural disruption. This allows educators to adapt the material based on local needs and priorities. A brief implementation roadmap is included in the accompanying materials.

Potential Value for the SEL Community

As AI becomes more present in learning environments, SEL organizations may increasingly encounter questions about how relational competencies apply in AI-mediated contexts.

This framework may offer a starting point for exploring how SEL competencies translate into AI interaction, how students develop responsible habits when using emerging tools, and how relational development can remain central as technology evolves.

This work is offered in the spirit of contribution and alignment rather than as a completed program.

Communication and Collaboration

Because this work is being developed independently, communication is most effective through written correspondence. Due to a health condition that limits meeting availability, the author typically works asynchronously and responds most effectively to questions and feedback by email. This allows thoughtful responses and careful refinement of ideas.

If helpful, questions, feedback, or requests for clarification are very welcome through written communication.

Conclusion

As AI becomes part of everyday learning environments, preparing students requires both technical familiarity and relational maturity. By connecting SEL principles with AI interaction, Be Kind to Your Robot Friends offers a small, practical entry point for educators exploring how to prepare students for responsible participation in AI-supported environments.

This overview is offered as a collaborative concept document. The accompanying framework document provides additional detail for those interested in deeper review. If the work appears aligned with SEL priorities, any perspective or guidance your team may be willing to share would be sincerely appreciated.